

STUDY SHEET

The word that makes separation

Torah: Genesis 1:1–6:8 · **Haftarah:** 1 Samuel 20:18–42 · **Gospel:** Matthew 24:29–36

God creates by speaking and separating; the Spirit hovers over the emptiness and the Word calls light and order. Sin is de-creation: the prophets use the image of tohu va-vohu for where sin ends up (though linguistically other words than hevel/riq). Cain grasps and lets sin rule; Jonathan — “the LORD has given” — receives and gives. Ruling over sin succeeds not from our own emptiness but by the Spirit. And when the lights go out, His word remains: “heaven and earth shall pass away, my words shall not” (24:35).

§0 Observation round

0.1 Blind observation

Genesis 1 creates by speaking: “and God said... and it was”; bara is used only for God’s creating. Light comes on day 1 (1:3), the lights (sun/moon/stars) only on day 4 (1:14-18), set “for signs and for seasons” (moadim). Seven times “it was good”; man in God’s image (1:27). Then Genesis 3: “she took... and ate” (grasping, wanting to be as God); the relationship breaks, the ground bears thorns. Genesis 5: eight times “and he died,” with Noah (“rest/comfort”) as exception. Genesis 6: “it repented the LORD... it grieved Him” (6:6), but “Noah found grace (chen) in the eyes of the LORD” (6:8). Haftarah (Machar Chodesh): “tomorrow is the new moon”; Jonathan’s covenant with David across the parting (“the LORD between us... for ever”). Gospel: the lights go out (Matt. 24:29), “heaven and earth shall pass away, my words shall not” (24:35), the hour known only to the Father (24:36).

0.2 The four axes as an open question

Does the weight fall on what God is and does (Source: the creating, remaining word), on the movement through time (Trajectory: beginning → fall → death → grace → end, and the renewal of the moon), on the wholeness of gift/grasp (Coherence: receiving vs grasping), or on the response (Will: hearing, abiding)?

0.3 The centre of gravity read off

● Load-bearing are **Source** and **Trajectory**: God speaks the world into being (gift), and that same word remains when the creation passes away (Matt. 24:35). Centre of gravity: the word that remains — from “in the beginning... and God said” to “my words shall not pass away,” with the gift of creation, the grasp of the fall, and an ending in grace (6:8).

0.4 Framing test

● Guarded. The weekly reflex (receiving vs grasping) is here not imposed but text-central: creation is the primal gift, the fall the primal grasp (“she took”). But the centre does not stay on that axis; the real deepening is the word-as-constant (Trajectory, Matt. 24:35). Guard: John 1:1-3 (the Logos in creation) and Matt. 24 are confessional horizon, not peshat-setter; the “speaking” in Genesis 1 is God’s word, not simply a doctrine of the Trinity.

§1 The thread

The world exists by a spoken word; it hangs on the Speaker, not on itself. So everything is gift before it is achievement. Man grasps what he was given to receive, and brings in death; God is grieved, and yet grace is found. And when at the end the lights go out and heaven and earth pass away, the word that called them remains.

§2 Peshat per block

Block	What it says (peshat)	Keyword / contrast	Open question
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	“In the beginning God created”;		
Gen. 1:1-5	“and God said, Let there be light”; light divided from darkness.	bara · and God said	Why does He create by speaking?
Gen. 1:14-19	The lights on day 4, “for signs and for seasons”.	light before the lights · moadim	Why light before sun and moon?
Gen. 1:26-31	Man in God’s image; all “very good”; the garden given.	image · very good · gift	What does the one prohibition mean?
Gen. 3:1-24	“Hath God said?”; “she took... and ate”; shame, blame, thorns, expulsion.	taking ↔ receiving	What breaks first?
Gen. 4-5	Cain and Abel; the genealogy with eight times “and he died”; Noah = rest.	“and he died” · rest	What does the rhythm of death say?
Gen. 6:1-8	Violence; “it repented the LORD... it grieved Him”; “Noah found grace”.	grief · grace (chen)	How does God’s sorrow stand beside grace?
1 Sam. 20:18-42	“Tomorrow is the new moon”; Jonathan’s loyalty above his throne; parting and covenant.	new moon · covenant remains	What remains when the ways divide?
Matt. 24:29-36	Sun/moon/stars go out; the Son of Man; “heaven and earth pass, my words not”; the hour known only to the Father.	lights go out · word remains	On what do you hang when the made perishes?

§3 Two load-bearing axes

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Source	1:3 · 1:14 · 6:8 · Matt. 24:35	Load-bearing. God creates and carries by His word; that word remains as the	Why light before the light-sources?

		creation passes; the ending is grace.	
		Load-bearing, second	
Trajectory	1:1 → 3:6 → 5 ("and he died") → 6:8 → Matt. 24:29- 35	pole. From beginning to fall to death to grace to end; and the moon that wanes and renews.	Is the end de- creation or fulfilment?
Coherence	1:29-30 (gift) ↔ 3:6 (grasp) · 1 Sam. 20:42 (covenant remains)	Supporting. Gift and grasp are the two basic postures; "receiving" the covenant word stands across the parting.	Where does become grasping again?
Will	3:6 (choosing) · Matt. 24:42 (watch)	Response, not source: hearing and abiding, or grasping and falling.	Is watching reckoning or trusting?

§4 Sources round

Van de Giessen covers Genesis 1–25; the rabbinic witnesses were verified via Sefaria.

● **Van de Giessen (pre-peshat).** Bara (1:1) is used in the Bible only for God's creating; cross-refs to John 1:1-3 and Heb. 11:3 (the world by the word). The light of day 1 (1:3) precedes the lights of day 4 — an old crux he discusses without forcing it. At 1:14 he notes the lights "for signs and seasons." And Noah (6) means "rest/comfort," a counter-note in the register of death.

● **Rashi on 1:14.** "Signs" points to the renewal of the moon — the lights govern the appointed times and the new moon. That ties the parashah directly to the Machar Chodesh haftarah.

● **Ibn Ezra on 1:14.** "Signs" may also point to hours and to lunar and solar eclipses — the lights as a measurable order, not as gods. Chizkuni places the lights in the firmament. Illustrative.

● **John 1:1-3 / Matthew 24 (confessional).** The creating word of Genesis 1 is confessed as the Logos who “in the beginning was with God” and became flesh; and “my words shall not pass away” (24:35) continues the enduring-word motif. Horizon, not peshat-setter.

● **De-creation in the prophets.** Jeremiah 4:23 and Isaiah 34:11 use the image of *tohu va-vohu* for the consequence of sin: the creation order is dismantled, the light taken away; Isaiah 45:18 says the opposite — God did not create the earth a *tohu* but to be inhabited. Precision note (set by the author): the “emptiness of sin” has its own roots (*hevel*, *shav*, *awen*, *riq*) and is linguistically not *tohu/bohu*; the link is thematic/theological, not lexical. Cassuto reads *tohu* as clay on the potter’s wheel — raw, waiting, not moral chaos.

● **Genesis 3:16 ↔ 4:7 (grammatical mirror).** The same syntax with *teshuqah* (desire) and *mashal* (rule): to Eve “he shall rule over you,” to Cain “you must rule over it” (*timshal-bo*). God reverses the axis: Cain is addressed on his moral sovereignty over the lurking drive. *Teshuqah* occurs in the whole Tanakh only 3× (Gen. 3:16; 4:7; Song 7:10).

●/● **Genesis 4:8 (text-critical gap).** The MT has “and Cain spoke to his brother Abel” without the direct speech; SP, LXX, Vulgate, Peshitta and Targum add “let us go into the field.” Three readings: scribal omission (*homoioteleuton* around “the field”), harmonisation by the translators, or deliberate *aposiopesis* — the omission then stressing that Cain’s words were mere pretext to lure him away from the witnesses.

● **Jonathan = “the LORD has given” (Yehonathan).** The name lays bare the contrast with Cain: grasping versus gift. Jonathan dismantles his dynastic claim and preserves the anointed (*hesed*); the empty place at Saul’s table (1 Sam. 20:18,25) stands against the covenant that remains whole (20:42). Two questions frame the *parashah*: “where are you?” (3:9, the Creator) and “where is your brother?” (4:9, the neighbour).

● **Onkelos on 1:1/1:3:** still to be verified.

Revision gate. Did the round shift the centre? Confirming: bara-as-God's-act-alone and "signs = new moon" (Rashi) strengthen Source/Trajectory and knot the three readings on one thread — the word that creates, sets the times, and remains.

§5 Direction test as horizon

● Confessional. The word by which God created "became flesh and dwelt among us" in Yeshua (John 1:14) — here, and only here, accommodation applies. And when in Matthew 24 the fourth-day lights go out, His word remains: whoever abides in it, abides. ● Guarded: Matt. 24 and John 1 do not settle the peshat of Genesis; "God said" is first of all God's creating speech.

§6 Status table

Claim	Status
God creates by speaking; bara only for God's act (1:1,3)	● load-bearing
Light (day 1) before the lights (day 4); lights "for signs and seasons" (1:14)	● load-bearing
"Signs" = renewal of the moon (Rashi) — tie to the Machar Chodesh haftarah	● load-bearing (verified)
PLACEHOLDER_EN ("she took and ate," 3:6); death as rhythm ("and he died," 5)	● load-bearing
God's grief (6:6) and grace (chen, 6:8) — the ending is grace, not judgment	● load-bearing
Reflex-landing on receiving/grasping without the word-constant	● guardrail
The creating word confessed as the Logos (John 1); "my words shall not pass" (Matt. 24:35)	● confessional
Onkelos on 1:1/1:3; Ibn Ezra "signs = eclipses"	●/● verification/suggestive

§7 Podcast rendering

One physical image: a child in a pitch-dark room flipping the light switch — and wanting to do it a hundred times, to pause over one wonder: there can be light, because He spoke it. And beside it the water and sand you mix and then watch separate again: creating is making separation, making clarity. So the Word works in a confused mind — it divides and clarifies, and it stands even when all the lights go out.

§8 Source accountability

Van de Giessen, Notes on Genesis (1–25): bara (1:1), light day 1 vs lights day 4, 1:14 “signs/seasons,” Noah = rest — from the file. Rashi and Ibn Ezra on 1:14, Chizkuni — verified via Sefaria. John 1:1-3,14 and Matt. 24:29-36 confessional (●). Onkelos: still to be verified. Name: Yeshua. Author: Arie Alberts.